M365-17 · Microsoft Forms & Bookings Standard

When a Form is the right instrument and when it is not, what may be collected in one, who owns it — and why Bookings appointments must never end up inside the ticket record.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-17
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 1 — the front door answers “can I use a Form for this?” from §2 and §3 in the conversation. Tier 2 creates group-owned Forms and Bookings pages. Tier 3 owns the tenant settings in §10.
Primary audience	End users who build Forms and Bookings pages — departmental staff and administrators. Also serves IT administrators, for §9 and §10.
Review cycle	Annually, and whenever a platform constraint in §4 is found to have changed. §4 is the section that goes stale.
Relationship to GOV-02	GOV-02 governs what a ticket is and how the queue is kept clean. §9 of this document is the Bookings half of that problem, and in many service desks it is a large half.

1. Purpose — two tools, two entirely different problems

Forms and Bookings are the two Microsoft 365 tools any member of staff can stand up in five minutes without asking anybody. That is mostly a good thing, and this document does not propose to change it. Two specific things go wrong, and neither is anyone’s fault.

The first is that platform limits are rediscovered per project. A typical example: somebody establishes, in a Teams thread, that Microsoft Forms will not accept file uploads from external or anonymous respondents — the uploaded file has to land in the tenant’s OneDrive or SharePoint, and a respondent with no identity in the tenant has nowhere to put it. That is a correct and useful finding. It gets recorded in a chat message. The next project that needs a document from somebody outside will find it out again, usually about a week before the deadline, and will spend the same afternoon on it.

The second is that Bookings writes into the record. When Bookings confirmations are addressed to the service desk, every appointment becomes a row in the ticketing system. Pull a ticket export to measure the desk and a large share of the rows turn out to be appointments and automated alerts rather than genuine human tickets. Measuring the service desk then requires forensic work before it can begin, and any baseline that comes out of it is qualified.

So this standard does two jobs: it writes the platform down once, in §4, so it stops being rediscovered, and it keeps Bookings out of the ticket queue, in §9.

2. When a Form is the right tool, and when it is not

Most of the trouble in this document is avoided by asking one question before building anything: is a Form actually the instrument for this?

If you need to...	Use	Because
Collect structured answers from people who have organization accounts	A Form. This is what it is for.	Authenticated, attributable, and the responses land where the organization controls them.
Collect a file from somebody outside the organization	Not a Form. See §4.1.	It does not work, it never has, and the failure only becomes visible after the form has gone out.
Take a payment	Never a Form. The office that owns the payment process.	Card data in a Form is a compliance problem that nobody in the conversation is authorised to accept (§3).
Let people book a slot or an appointment	Bookings, not a Form.	A Form cannot hold a slot, prevent a double booking or send a reminder. People build appointment Forms and then manage the clashes by hand.
Raise something that IT needs to act on	The service desk intake (GOV-02).	A Form that emails a person is not a ticket. It has no priority, no owner, no history and no SLA.
Route something through approvals and onward steps	Not a Form. Power Platform (M365-19) or an application (ACC-16).	Forms collects. It does not route, approve, remind or escalate, and building those around it by hand is how an unregistered flow starts.
Collect genuinely anonymous feedback	A Form — but read §6 first.	“Anonymous” has a precise technical meaning and an imprecise everyday one, and the gap is where promises get broken.
Collect anything about a named person that will be kept	A Form is fine as the collector — but §3, §5 and §7 apply from the first response.	The responses are the record. What matters is not the form, it is the workbook it fills.

3. What may be collected in a Form

The general rule is short: the handling rules that apply to a piece of data do not change because it arrived through a Form. Classification follows the sensitive classes proposed in M365-15, and the responses inherit the permissions of wherever they land (§7).

> **Three things never go in a Microsoft Form. No exceptions, no approvals, no “just this once”.**
> SOCIAL SECURITY NUMBERS, in whole or in part. Not the last four digits either — a partial SSN alongside a name and a date of birth is not a de-identified value, it is a slightly shorter identifier.
> PAYMENT CARD DATA — number, expiry, security code, or an image of a card. Collecting card data in a Form brings the organization’s card handling into a scope nobody in that conversation has the authority to accept, and the response workbook then has to be treated as cardholder data for as long as it exists.
> HEALTH INFORMATION — including anything collected for a disability accommodation, a medical absence, an immunisation record, or a wellbeing check. There are offices that own each of these and they have instruments that are built for it.
>
> The reason is structural, not a matter of care. Forms has no field-level protection, no masking, and no way to make one answer more protected than another; the responses arrive in an ordinary workbook that is as shareable as any other file; and the person who builds the form is very often not the person who would be asked to assess the risk. If you have been asked to collect one of these, that is the moment to ask the service desk rather than to build it carefully.

Below that hard line, judgement applies:

- Regulated client records, personnel matters and payroll data may be collected in a Form only where the form is group-owned (§5), restricted to authenticated respondents (§6), and the responses land in a site with the right handling controls (§7). If any of those three is not true, the answer is no.
- Do not collect a field because it might be useful. Every field is a field that has to be protected, retained and eventually disposed of, and the ones that get the organization into difficulty are almost always the ones nobody needed.
- A form that asks for an organization password, or that asks somebody to “verify their account”, is a phishing form whatever the intent behind it. IT will never ask for that and neither should you (ACC-15 §4, M365-22).

4. Recorded platform constraints

Each line in this section is a constraint that has cost somebody an afternoon. The rule is that a constraint discovered twice is a documentation failure rather than a Microsoft one.

Constraint	What it means in practice	Confirmed
File uploads from external or anonymous respondents	Not possible. An uploaded file has to be written into the tenant — the owner’s OneDrive, or the owning group’s SharePoint site — and a respondent with no identity in the tenant has no way to write it. The upload question is simply not offered when the form is open to anyone. Design around it before the form goes out (§4.1).	Standing
Upload size and count limits, internally	Even internally there is a limit on file count and size, and it is lower than people assume. Verify the current figure before designing a process around uploads, and record it on this line at the next review.	Not verified

Constraint	What it means in practice	Confirmed
Forms is not a workflow tool	No approvals, routing, reminders or escalation, and no conditional logic beyond simple branching. What people build around a Form to supply those is either manual work somebody will stop doing, or an unregistered flow (M365-19).	Standing
Anonymous responses cannot be de-anonymised	By design, and correctly. It also means you cannot follow up, correct a mistaken entry, or enforce one response per person. IT cannot recover the identity later; there is nothing to recover (§6).	Standing
Responses land in an ordinary workbook	Every sharing, permission and retention rule that applies to a spreadsheet applies to them (M365-11, M365-16). The Form is not the record. The workbook is.	Standing
Deleting the Form deletes the responses	There is no habit of recovery here that people can rely on. Export first if the responses matter, and put the export where records go (§7).	Standing
Forms does not enforce classification	A field labelled “SSN” is a text field to the platform. Nothing warns, nothing blocks, nothing labels. §3 is enforced by the person building the form and by nobody else.	Standing
A link is not an access control	An “anyone can respond” link is public the moment somebody forwards it, and people forward things (§6). Long surveys and high-volume collections also hit platform ceilings on questions and responses — check before you build.	Standing

> **How this section is maintained — and it is the whole point of the section**
>
> When anybody in IT establishes a platform limit the hard way, it is added here as one line with a date, raised as a document amendment under GOV-01. That is the entire mechanism. It requires no project and no meeting.
>
> Lines marked “Not verified” are honest gaps: the constraint is real, the current number is not confirmed, and stating that is more useful than printing a figure somebody would then rely on.

4.1 What to do instead when you need a file from outside the organization

1. Create or identify a SharePoint document library for the purpose, owned by the department (M365-10).
2. Share it with a link scoped to the people who need to upload, with an expiry, under M365-14. Where the population is genuinely unknown in advance, use a request-files link into a folder they cannot read back.
3. Use the Form for the structured answers and the library for the file, with a reference number joining the two. Two instruments, each doing what it is built for.
4. Where the volume is small, a monitored departmental shared mailbox is often the better answer (M365-03). People know how to attach a file to an email.
5. If the file contains anything in §3, none of the above applies and the request goes to the office that owns that data.

5. Ownership — a Form owned by a person dies with the person

A Form created in the ordinary way belongs to the individual who created it, and lives in their account. When they change role or leave and their account is handled under ACC-01 §7, the form and its responses go with it. Nobody is notified, because nothing has failed — the form simply stops being anybody's. This is the same pathology as organization records held in a personal OneDrive on a different surface, and it has the same fix: the asset belongs to the group, not to the person who happened to build it.

> **The rule**
>
> Any Form that supports an organization process — anything a department depends on, anything collecting data that will be kept, anything published beyond the person who built it — is created as a GROUP form, owned by a Microsoft 365 group.
>
> This is one extra click at the moment of creation and it is the entire control. A group form can be handed on, reviewed, and found by somebody other than its author. A personal form can be transferred only by its owner, and only while they still have an account — which is to say, only before the moment you need it.

1. Create it in the group. In Forms, choose a new group form and pick the department's group rather than accepting the default of your own account.
2. If it already exists as a personal form, move it now, while you still can. Forms supports transferring a form to a group. Doing this today takes two minutes; doing it after somebody has left is not possible.
3. Personal forms remain entirely appropriate for personal things — a straw poll in a meeting, a lunch order, a quick check with four colleagues. The test is whether anybody but you would miss it.
4. The group owner is accountable for what it collects (§3), who can read the responses (§7), and closing it when the thing it was for has finished. An open form collecting responses nobody reads is a data holding with no purpose.
5. At separation, the manager checklist asks about Forms and Bookings pages alongside sites and mailboxes (ACC-01 §7.2, ACC-12 Appendix A). This is the only routine moment at which an orphaned form is caught.

> **Open question — the forms nobody knows exist**
>
> IT cannot currently produce a list of every Form in the tenant with its owner. Administrative reporting for Forms is thin, and this document is honest that §5 is therefore enforced at the moment of creation and by convention, not by audit.
>
> ACTION: Tier 3 to establish what reporting is available — group forms are discoverable through the groups that own them, personal forms largely are not — and report to Tier 4 within 90 days of approval. If nothing useful exists, say so, and rely on §5 and the leaver checklist rather than claiming a control the organization does not have. Owner: Tier 3, reporting to the Head of IT.

6. Anonymous or authenticated

This is a two-click setting with consequences people do not expect, in both directions.

Setting	What it actually means	Use when
Only people in my organisation can respond, name recorded	The respondent signs in and their name and address are captured against the response.	The default for anything operational. Anything you may need to follow up on, anything where one response per person matters, anything collecting the classes in §3's second half.
Only people in my organisation can respond, name not recorded	The respondent still has to sign in, so the audience is restricted, but the form owner does not see who said what.	Internal feedback where anonymity has been promised. This is the right setting for most "anonymous" surveys, and it is not the one people usually pick.
Anyone with the link can respond	No sign-in, no identity, and the form is open to the internet the moment the link leaves the building.	Genuine public collection — an event registration, an enquiry form. Never for anything in §3, and never where a response needs to be attributable.

- If you promise anonymity, do not then ask for department, site, role and length of service. In a department of six people, three demographic questions are a name. This is the most common way an anonymous survey stops being anonymous, and it is always accidental.
- An anonymous form cannot be de-anonymised afterwards. If somebody discloses something that needs a response, there is no route back to them — so say in the form itself where they should go if they want a reply. For the same reason, one response per person cannot be enforced.
- Restricting to the organisation is not the same as restricting to the right people. Everybody in the tenant can respond, including temporary workers and, depending on §10, guests. Where the audience matters, say so in the form and check the responses.

7. Where responses live, and how long they last

- Responses to a GROUP form live in the owning group's SharePoint site. Responses to a PERSONAL form live in the creator's OneDrive. That single sentence is most of the argument for §5.
- The response workbook is an ordinary file. Whoever can reach the site or the OneDrive can reach the responses, subject to the permissions that are actually set there rather than the ones people assume (M365-11).
- Exporting to Excel creates a copy, and a copy in somebody's Downloads folder is outside every control the organization has. If the responses matter, the export goes to the departmental site (M365-12).
- Retention follows the location, not the form. Responses in a group site are covered by the site's policy; responses in a OneDrive are covered by M365-16 §5, which is to say they are at risk once the account is unlicensed. A survey with 400 responses is a record.
- CLOSE a form to stop new responses. DELETE it only as a deliberate disposition decision, with the responses either exported to the right place first or genuinely not needed. Tidying up is not a disposition process (M365-16 §2).
- Where a form collects anything in the sensitive classes of M365-15, name in the form itself how long responses will be kept and what they will be used for. People answer more honestly when they know, and it forces the builder to decide.

8. Bookings — creation, naming and staff calendars

8.1 Who may create a Bookings page

Bookings pages are requested through the service desk and created by Tier 2, owned by a department rather than an individual. The reasons are §5's reasons, plus §9's: a Bookings page publishes an address, exposes staff calendars, and writes notifications into mailboxes — three things that should be decided rather than discovered.

- Every page has a named departmental owner and a named deputy.
- Every page has a stated purpose and a review date, and is reviewed annually with everything else under ACC-17.
- A page for a service that no longer exists still accepts bookings. Retiring a service includes retiring its booking page, and that is the owner's job.

8.2 Naming

The name appears in the invitation, in the calendar entry, in the confirmation email and often in a URL sent to people outside the organization. It is a public artefact.

Instead of	Name it
"Appointments"	Records Office — Records Requests
"Book Now"	Finance — Expense Claim Consultations
A person's name and calendar	HR — New Starter Onboarding. Staff are assigned inside the page; the page is the service, not the person.
"Test", "New Booking Page", "Copy of…"	Either name it properly at creation or delete it. Test pages that survive become live pages nobody owns.

Format: — . The department comes first because that is what somebody scanning a list of pages needs. Align to the object naming conventions in ACC-02 and M365-07 where they apply.

8.3 Staff calendar exposure — the part people do not expect

Adding somebody as staff on a Bookings page connects their calendar to a booking engine. Where availability is set to follow the Microsoft 365 calendar, the page reads that calendar continuously and hands out whatever it finds free.

- Nobody is added as Bookings staff without being told and agreeing. Becoming bookable is a change to somebody's working life, not a configuration detail, and it is usually done by a colleague with good intentions and no conversation.
- Set business hours on the page rather than relying on the calendar to be complete. A personal appointment marked "free", or a block of thinking time nobody put in the calendar, becomes a slot a user can take.

- Set buffer time, minimum lead time and maximum lead time at creation. A page that lets somebody book a 9.00 appointment at 8.55 will generate complaints, and they will arrive at the service desk rather than at the department that configured it.
- Decide deliberately whether staff names and addresses are published on an externally-facing page. For most externally-facing services the answer is the service address, not the individual.
- Where a page is external-facing, the confirmation and reminder text is part of the organization's voice. Read it once before publishing.

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9. Bookings must not write into the ticket queue

> **The rule**
> A Bookings page does not write into the ticketing system. No confirmation, reminder, cancellation, reschedule notice or staff notification from a Bookings page is addressed to the service desk address, or to any other address that creates a ticket.
> This applies to pages owned by IT as well. Especially to pages owned by IT.

The reason shows up the first time anybody tries to report on the queue. Producing a ticket report means taking the raw export and working out what each row actually is: Bookings appointments, automated alerts, genuine human tickets. Establishing even that requires heuristics across submitter name, address and title, with a residue of rows set aside for manual review.

None of that is analysis. It is archaeology, performed before any analysis can start, on a queue that should have been able to answer the question directly.

> **And the figures will not reconcile — which is the argument, not an aside**
> Categories counted by heuristic rarely add back up to the total. A few dozen rows end up in two categories, or in the manual-review pile, or are caught by a filter applied at a different point.
> Nobody does anything wrong, and the gap is usually small. The problem is that it cannot be resolved without going back to the raw export and repeating the work, because the queue itself does not distinguish an appointment from a ticket. A queue that has to be reconstructed to be counted cannot produce a baseline anybody should build an SLA on (GOV-06).
> That is why this is a rule and not a suggestion.

9.1 How it is implemented

1. Bookings notifications are addressed to a departmental shared mailbox (M365-03) or to the assigned staff member. Never to an intake address.
2. Tier 3 audits every existing Bookings page in the tenant for notification addresses that reach the service desk queue, and corrects them. OWNER: Tier 3. DUE: within 30 days of approval. This is a finite task with a known end.
3. Where a booking genuinely should create a ticket — an IT appointment that ought to be tracked and closed — that is designed deliberately under GOV-02 with its own ticket category and its own queue treatment, not produced as a side effect of a confirmation email nobody chose.

4. Appointments that must remain visible in the ticketing system for a legitimate reason are categorised so that they can be excluded from ticket counts at source. Excluding them at source is better than excluding them in the report, because a report is written by one person once and the queue is read by everybody forever.
5. GOV-02 owns the categorisation. This document owns the rule that produces the need for it.

10. Tenant settings

Tier 3 owns these; changes go through M365-21. Recorded here so that the intent sits alongside the standard rather than only in a console.

Setting	Intent
Who can create Forms	All licensed users. Restricting this would push people to consumer survey tools outside the tenant, which is worse in every respect. The control is §3 and §5, not prohibition.
Forms external sharing / anonymous responses	Permitted, subject to §6. Turning it off would break legitimate public collection.
Forms credential-harvesting detection	Left enabled. A form that asks for a password is blocked by the platform, which is a genuine protection given how convincing an internal-looking Form can be (M365-22).
Who can create Bookings pages	Restricted to a named group. End-user creation is off — this is what makes §8.1 a standard rather than a wish.
Bookings staff approval	Staff must approve being added to a page where the platform supports it, so §8.3 is a configuration and not a courtesy.
Bookings external publishing default	Off by default; enabled per page on request, so that publishing to the internet is a decision.

11. Service levels

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
“Can I use a Form for this?”	Answered at Tier 1 from §2, in the conversation, without a ticket.
Group form creation, or moving a personal form to a group	P3 — 2 coverage days.
Bookings page creation, complete request	P3 — 3 coverage days.
A form found to be collecting anything in §3	Same coverage day. The form is closed first and discussed afterwards.
Bookings notification found writing into the ticket queue	Corrected same coverage day (§9.1).
Adding a newly discovered constraint to §4	At the point of discovery, by whoever discovered it, under GOV-01.

12. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Form responses	Owning group's SharePoint site (§7)	Per the site's retention policy, M365-16
Exports of responses	Departmental site — never a personal drive	As the record they constitute
Bookings page register: page, owner, deputy, purpose, review date	IT register	Life of the page + 1 year
Bookings appointment history	Bookings calendar / owning mailbox	Per M365-16
Staff consent to being added to a booking page	Ticket	3 years
Constraint discoveries added to §4	This document, via GOV-01	Permanent — the point is that it accumulates

13. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
GOV-02	Service Desk Intake, Ticket Quality & Categorisation	§9 is the Bookings half of ticket hygiene. GOV-02 owns the categorisation.
M365-15	Data Classification & Handling	What §3 means by sensitive.
M365-16	Retention, Legal Hold & eDiscovery	§7 — responses are records and follow the location they land in.
M365-11	SharePoint & OneDrive Permission Management	Who can read the response workbook.
M365-14	External Sharing & Guest Access Governance	§4.1 — the supported way to receive a file from outside.
M365-03	Shared Mailbox Standard	Where Bookings notifications go instead of the queue.
M365-19	Power Platform Governance	What people build around a Form when Forms will not do it (§2).
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle	§7 leaver checklist — the moment an orphaned form is caught.
ACC-17	Periodic Access Review	Annual review of Bookings pages and their owners.
M365-21	Tenant Configuration Change Control	Changes to §10.
GOV-01	SOP Catalog Governance	How a new §4 line gets added.

ID	Title	Relationship
GOV-06	Service Commitments, Priority & Escalation	Supplies §11.

Appendix A — Before you publish: a checklist

Five minutes before the form or page goes out. The Evidence column is what you would point at if somebody asked.

✓	Step	Evidence
☐	The form is owned by a group, not by me personally (§5)	The group name shown in Forms
☐	It collects nothing in the hard-stop list — no SSN, no card data, no health information (§3)	The question list
☐	The audience setting matches what I have promised respondents (§6)	The setting, and the wording of the form
☐	If I promised anonymity, nothing in the questions identifies a small group (§6)	The question list, read as a stranger would
☐	I am not asking external respondents to upload a file (§4)	The question types used
☐	I know where the responses will land and who can read them (§7)	The site or OneDrive, and its permissions
☐	BOOKINGS: the page is named — (§8.2)	The page name
☐	BOOKINGS: every member of staff on the page knows they are on it (§8.3)	The conversation, or the ticket
☐	BOOKINGS: business hours, buffer and lead times are set — not left at default (§8.3)	The page configuration
☐	BOOKINGS: no notification address reaches the service desk address or creates a ticket (§9)	The notification settings
☐	There is a named owner and a deputy, and a date to review this	The register entry

Appendix B — For end users: the plain version

Source text for the knowledge base, format per GOV-05. This is the version people will actually read.

Forms and Bookings are genuinely useful and you do not need permission to use them for ordinary things. A few points will save you an afternoon.

Build it in your group, not in your own account	When you create a Form, choose your department’s group rather than accepting the default. It takes one extra click. A form built in your personal account belongs to your account, and if you change role or leave, it goes with you — along with every response in it. Nobody gets a warning; it just stops being anybody’s. If you have already built one that your department relies on, move it into the group today. You can do that yourself, and you can only do it while you still have the account.

People outside the organization cannot upload files to a Form	This one catches everybody. Microsoft Forms cannot accept a file from somebody who does not have an organization account, because the file has to be saved into our own storage and they have nowhere to save it to. It is not a setting and it is not something IT can turn on. If you need a document from a job applicant, a customer or a vendor, ask the service desk — we will set up a folder they can upload into, or a mailbox they can email.
Three things never go in a Form	Social Security numbers, card details, and anything medical. Not even the last four digits of an SSN, and not even “just for this one event”. If somebody has asked you to collect one of these, that is exactly the moment to ask us — there is nearly always a proper route, and it is usually quicker than the workaround.
“Anonymous” means something specific	If you promise anonymity, set the form so it does not record names — and then be careful what else you ask. In a team of six, asking for department, role and length of service is asking for their name. And it stays anonymous: if somebody tells you something worrying, there is no way for anyone, including us, to find out who they were.
The responses are a real record	They live in a spreadsheet in your group’s site, and anyone who can get into that site can read them. If you export to Excel, that copy is out of our reach — please keep it in the department’s site. And when the thing is finished, close the form rather than deleting it, unless you are sure nobody needs what is in it.
Use Bookings for appointments, not a Form	A Form cannot hold a slot or stop two people booking the same time, so people end up sorting out clashes by hand. Bookings does all of that, sends the reminders, and handles cancellations. Ask us for a page and we will set it up with your business hours and a sensible amount of notice.
Tell colleagues before you add them to a booking page	Adding somebody as staff makes them bookable and connects the page to their calendar. That is a real change to someone’s day and it should be a conversation first. And if a slot looks free in their calendar the page will offer it, so set proper business hours rather than relying on the calendar being complete.
Booking confirmations must not go to the service desk	Please do not put the service desk address on a Bookings page. Every confirmation becomes a ticket, and when anyone tries to count the real tickets, separating out the appointments takes days. Send confirmations to your departmental mailbox instead — and if you are not sure which address that is, or whether a Form is the right tool at all, just ask. There is no ticket needed and nobody minds being asked.

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.